

Interpretive Methods in the Study of Politics

Researching populism as an example

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What's the difference between a wink and a blink?

(Ein Zwinkern versus ein Blinzeln)



Clifford Geertz, Interpretation, and “Thick Description”:

- A wink is a symbol. It communicates meaning
- Clifford Geertz’s concept of “**thick description**”, introduced in his influential essay “Thick Description: Toward an Interpretive Theory of Culture” (1973), distinguished between a wink and a blink
- Geertz argued that human behaviour cannot be understood purely in terms of external, observable actions (**thin description**).
- Instead, actions must be contextualized within the **symbolic frameworks and meanings** that individuals and groups assign to them.

Interpreting Intentions and Context:

- **Thick description** focuses on understanding the **intentions** behind actions and the **contexts** in which they occur.
- For example, the same action—a wink—can have different meanings depending on cultural norms, situational context, and the relationship between the people involved. A wink might signify flirtation, sarcasm, irony, humour, resistance, conspiracy, etc.



Dvora Yanow (2009): Interpretive research in political science (assigned reading)

Archaeologists search for concrete artifacts. Those artifacts are concrete objects, through which the researcher learns about a complex political-social-economic world.



Interpretive researchers studying politics do something similar. Gather data on language, actions, physical artifacts.



“The reason that interpretive researchers ...ground their studies in human language (written, oral, nonverbal), acts, and physical artifacts is that these provide the bases for inferring underlying meanings.... Being able to point to specific words, deeds, and objects enables meaning-oriented inferences to be ‘tested’.” (p. 432)

Yanow continued:

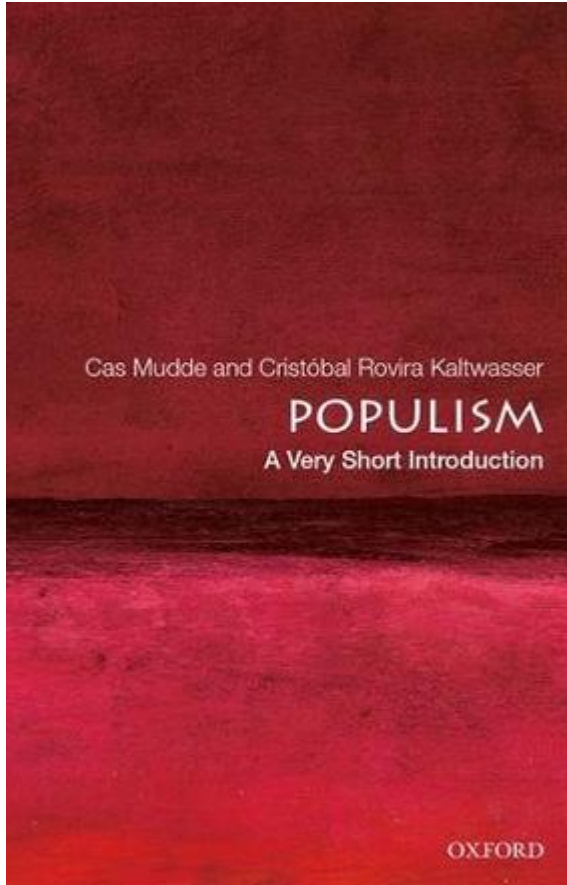
- Understanding the system of meanings, and symbols, to explain power, ideologies, political beliefs
- **Premised on a view that individuals cannot be reduced to specific variables, but are enmeshed in a wide network of meanings.**
- These meanings are made concrete through speech, action, physical artifacts which the researcher can gather as data and study
- The researcher (observer) is not observing only external behaviours (e.g. voting choice), but seeks to understand *why and how they engage in political choices and forms of politics* by *seeing humans as embedded in a wide network of meanings and culture*.

Interpretive methods methods”

“Qualitative

- “Interpretive methods” are **not** a synonym for “qualitative methods.”
- Although there is much overlap between the two.
- BUT; one can conduct a qualitative research study which is not interpretive.

Example: Qualitative but NOT interpretive



Populism: Influential book edited by political scientists Mudde and Kaltwasser (2017)

Compares populist movements in Latin America and Europe

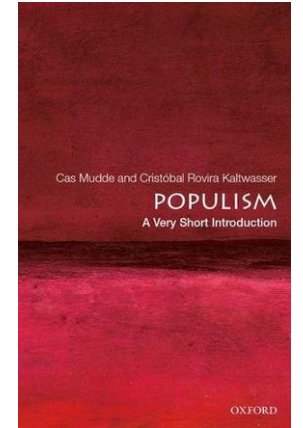
The research design is **qualitative** and **comparative** analysis

Data sources: Party documents, party manifestos, elite (leader) speeches, media reporting

Looking at both leftwing populism in Latin American, and rightwing populism in Europe, conclude that populism relies on a simple formula

Mudde and Kaltwasser conclude:

Populism, on both left and right is a ‘thin’ ideology which:



1. Divides society into **“the pure people”** versus **“the corrupt elites.”**
2. Claims that politics should express the **will of the “real” people.**

This is qualitative research, but not interpretive. They are not trying to understand, for example, why and how citizens are attracted by a politician who claims to represent the real people.

Examples of interpretive methods we will review today (this is not a comprehensive list):

- Interviews
- Participant Observation
- Discourse/narrative analysis

Interviews

Interviews as interpretive methods:

- In-depth interviews are **structured or semi-structured** conversations where the researcher probes individuals to gain detailed insights into their perspectives, experiences, life histories, social background and motivations.
- **Structured interviews** = A structured set of questions asked systematically to each person who is interviewed.
- **Semi-structured interviews** = Questions which repeat across interviewees, but also are open to unexpected topics and new questions
- The goal is to understand meanings, beliefs, and choices.

Back to studying populist radical right politics as an example

From my own research:

Dorit Geva, Daughter, Mother, Captain: Marine Le Pen, Gender, and Populism in the French National Front, *Social Politics: International Studies in Gender, State & Society*, Volume 27, Issue 1, Spring 2020, Pages 1–26, <https://doi.org/10.1093/sp/jxy039>

How (if at all) did followers of Marine Le Pen in the years following her election as populist radical right party leader view her leadership as a woman in an historically masculine party?

****Remember, definition of populism:**

- 1. Divides the 'real' and 'pure' people against elites**
- 2. Politics (specific leaders and/or parties) claim to represent the true people**

Sample of interviewees, comparing between two generations (there were more than listed here):

Table A1. Summary of interviewees

Party	Sex	Age	Location	Occupation
FNJ				
1	M	20	Nantes (Loire-Atlantique)	Student
2	M	24	Paris	Student
3	M	24	Boulogne-Billancourt (Île-de France)	Banker
4	M	20	Paris	Student
5	M	24	Chambéry (Savoie)	Student
6	M	19	Paris	Baker
7	F	21	Paris	Media (radio PR)
8	M	22	Val-de-Marne (Île-de-France)	Student
9	M	22	Boulogne-Billancourt (Île-de France)	Caregiver
10	M	24	Val-de-Marne (Île-de-France)	Student
11	M	26	Bourges (Loire Valley)	Baker
12	F	25	Bourges (Loire valley)	Shop-seller
13	F	23	Paris	Student
14	F	17	Paris	Student
15	M	20	Paris	Student
16	M	26	Lyon (Rhône)	Student
17	F	23	Vaires-sur-Marne (Île-de-France)	Nurse; and Student
18	M	24	Grenoble (Isère)	Student
19	M	25	Calais (Pas-de-Calais)	Insurance broker
20	F	23	Houilles (Île-de-France)	Unemployed
FN and FNJ				
1	M	23	Normandy	Member of Municipal Council
2	F	21	Strasbourg (Bas-Rhin)	Member of Municipal Council
3	F	24	Arceuil (Île-de-France)	Legal aid; Member of Municipal Council
4	M	27	Toulouse (Haute-Garonne)	Member of Regional Council

What interviews revealed:

- Followers' belief that Marine Le Pen is “against the elites,” and represents the true people expressed in highly gendered imagery
- Some referred to her explicitly as a **maternal figure**, not just one of those elite men in suits
- Others – more surprisingly – admired her also as a woman with very **masculine** features; more of a man than the men of the “corrupt elites.”

Maternity:

“Marine Le Pen embodies **this image of a woman who is a mother**, and who is politically effective... she isn't a man, and she gives politics a new image, a matriarchal image. That's it, **she's the mother of the family, she's the one who takes care of her children, little French children, putting them on the right path.**”

Masculine Virility

“There are few woman... who display, I dare say, as virile a force as her. It’s rare [...] It’s always nice to see a woman who can lead a great political movement, France’s premier party, **like a man. With force, with conviction, with righteousness, with honor. These are qualities which are, quote unquote, masculine.**”

Masculine Authority

“She has that verve, that strong fist, which makes her a real head of state. In the Fifth Republic’s constitution, General de Gaulle dictated the constitution so that the head of state would be a captain [...] **I absolutely see Marine Le Pen in this captain’s suit.** Whereas someone like [former president] François Hollande or [former president] Nicolas Sarkozy - for me this isn’t a suit tailored for them.”

Interviews revealed that Marine Le Pen's populist appeal is made meaningful **through her femininity and masculinity**

1. Dividing the 'real' and 'pure' people against elites:

- Made meaningful by seeing her as a protective mother figure
- Made meaningful by contrasting her as more of a man than the corrupt elite men

2. A specific leader/party claims represents the 'true people' unlike mainstream elites:

- Also made meaningful through the maternal view of her
- And likening her to a soldier, a general – not a professional politician

Strengths and Weaknesses of Interview Methods:

□ Strengths

- **Rich, detailed data:** Allows researchers to capture complex beliefs, emotions, and reasoning processes behind political behaviour.
- **Participant perspective:** Prioritizes how political actors or citizens themselves understand political phenomena.
- **Flexible and adaptive:** Interviewers can adjust questions based on the flow of conversation or emerging themes.

□ □ Challenges

- **Time-consuming:** Requires significant effort to conduct, transcribe, and analyze.
- **Limited generalizability:** Smaller sample sizes reduce the ability to make broad claims.
- **Interviewer bias:** The researcher's presence, tone, or wording can influence responses.
- **Interviewer profile impacts answers:** e.g., social class, race
- **Data complexity:** The richness of the data makes systematic comparison challenging.
- **Access issues:** Gaining trust or access can be challenging.
- **Research ethics:** Consent, data protection, and privacy need to be secured.

Participant Observation

Participant Observation:

- **Research observes “natural settings”**: the researcher engages with a community or group to study their practices, beliefs, and social interactions
- The goal is to understand the lived experiences and cultural contexts that shape political behaviors, institutions, and ideologies.
- The researcher seeks to interpret how people make sense of their social and political realities, rather than testing predefined categories or variables
- A central premise to is that even apparently spontaneous moments are highly structured, and with extensive observation patterns and repeated meanings emerge

Example of observations – learning about populism:

Again, from: Dorit Geva, Daughter, Mother, Captain: Marine Le Pen, Gender, and Populism in the French National Front, *Social Politics: International Studies in Gender, State & Society*, Volume 27, Issue 1, Spring 2020, Pages 1–26, <https://doi.org/10.1093/sp/jxy039>

- Immersed in the world of local party activism in the south of France, especially around Nice in 2013
- Attended national and local events, **and informal** social events, individual meetings with activists at cafes, sometimes in their homes (more rare)
- In a second phase; based in Lyon, a traditionally Catholic-bourgeois city politically, where the party was also making inroads (2016-2017)

May 1 march in Paris, 2013: On stage:



Off-stage: MLP's corporality

- Met a group of retired women, lifelong party supports, from Nice. The traditional base of the party from the south of France
- Very excited that **'the daughter'** they had seen grow up in the party – like their own child – was now party leader
- As MLP was delivering her party speech on May 1, 2013, they **kept on talking about their leader's legs. They were not listening to the speech**
- I went for lunch with them – and they opened my contacts to the Nice party branch
- At lunch, and as a continued theme I encountered for years of research, **constant discussion of MLP's towering legs.**
- Eventually I understood: **MLP's legs, and who has seen them in person was a mark of who is a real 'insider' in the party, who belonged inside the party 'family'**

What do discussions of MLP's body tell us about populism?

Activists spent a lot of time discussing her body – rather than party ideology.

- **Familiar intimacy: Gossip** collapses distance between the people and the leader — Marine becomes “**one of us.**”
- **Embodied authenticity:** Her physical presence makes her seem real and **authentic**, not abstract like elite politicians.
- **Insider belonging:** Knowing and talking about her body marks who truly **belongs** within the party community. Who had seen her in a mini-skirt.
- **Fetishization of her body made her relatable.**

In other words...

Gender gives form and meaning to populism. It makes it 'real' and relatable.

The body, clothes, appearance of their political leader gave concrete form to how Marine Le Pen is “unlike liberal elites” and “one of the people”

Strengths/Challenges of Participant Observation:

□ Strengths:

- Provides rich, context-sensitive insights into power dynamics, political identity formation, and symbolic practices.
- Does not artificially extract people from their 'real lives,' observations in a natural setting
- Over extensive observations, patterns emerge from apparently spontaneous interactions
- Surprising themes emerge which are difficult to predict in advance

□ □ Challenges :

- Findings are often difficult to generalize beyond the specific context studied.
- Time-intensive
- Reliant on the researcher's interpretive lens, which may introduce bias
- Reliant on access
- Open complex questions of research ethics. **Protecting privacy** is critically important.
- **We don't always like the people we study** and who even invite researchers into their homes – also ethically complex

Discourse Analysis

Discourse analysis as interpretive method

Definition:

- Discourse analysis examines how language, symbols, and texts – including visuals – construct reality

Key Features:

- Studies the role of language, symbols, and images in shaping power and politics
- Investigates how narratives are constructed, contested, and institutionalized.
- **Can be qualitative, or quantitative, or both**

Application in Political Science:

- **Example:** Analyzing political speeches or campaign ads to uncover the rhetorical strategies used across political parties

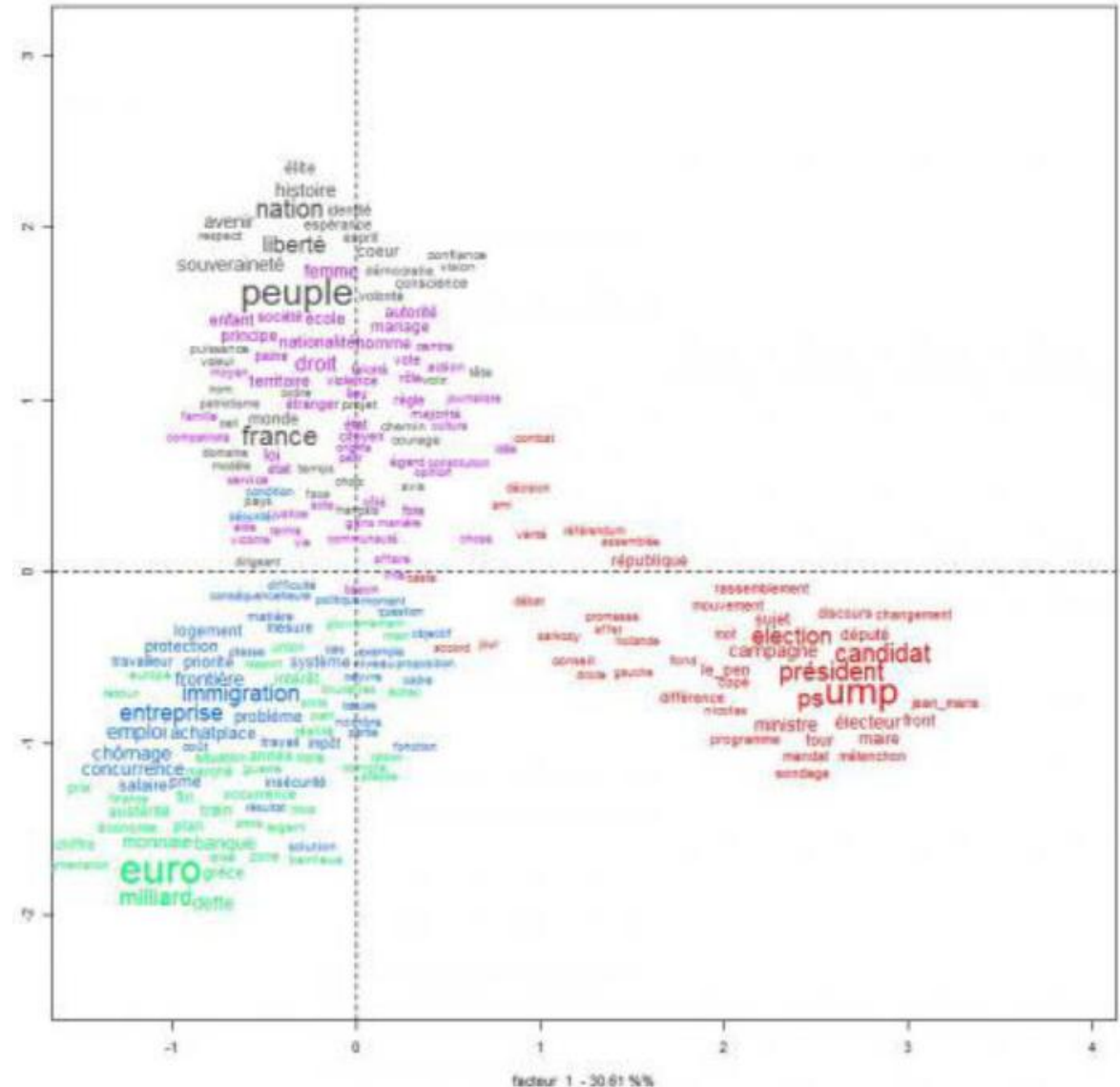
Example with large data:

Cécile Alduy et Stéphane Wahnich (2015)

Analyzed **500 speeches** by Marine Le Pen to study how she transformed the party, especially in comparison to her father.

Her strategies of discursive normalization

Quantitative and qualitative methods



Their Findings: The Language of Respectable Radical-Right Populism

For example: “**Semantic reframing**” (i.e. changing the words used, compared to her father when he was party president)

Replaces “race” and “foreigners” with “culture,” “identity,” “values,” and “protection.”

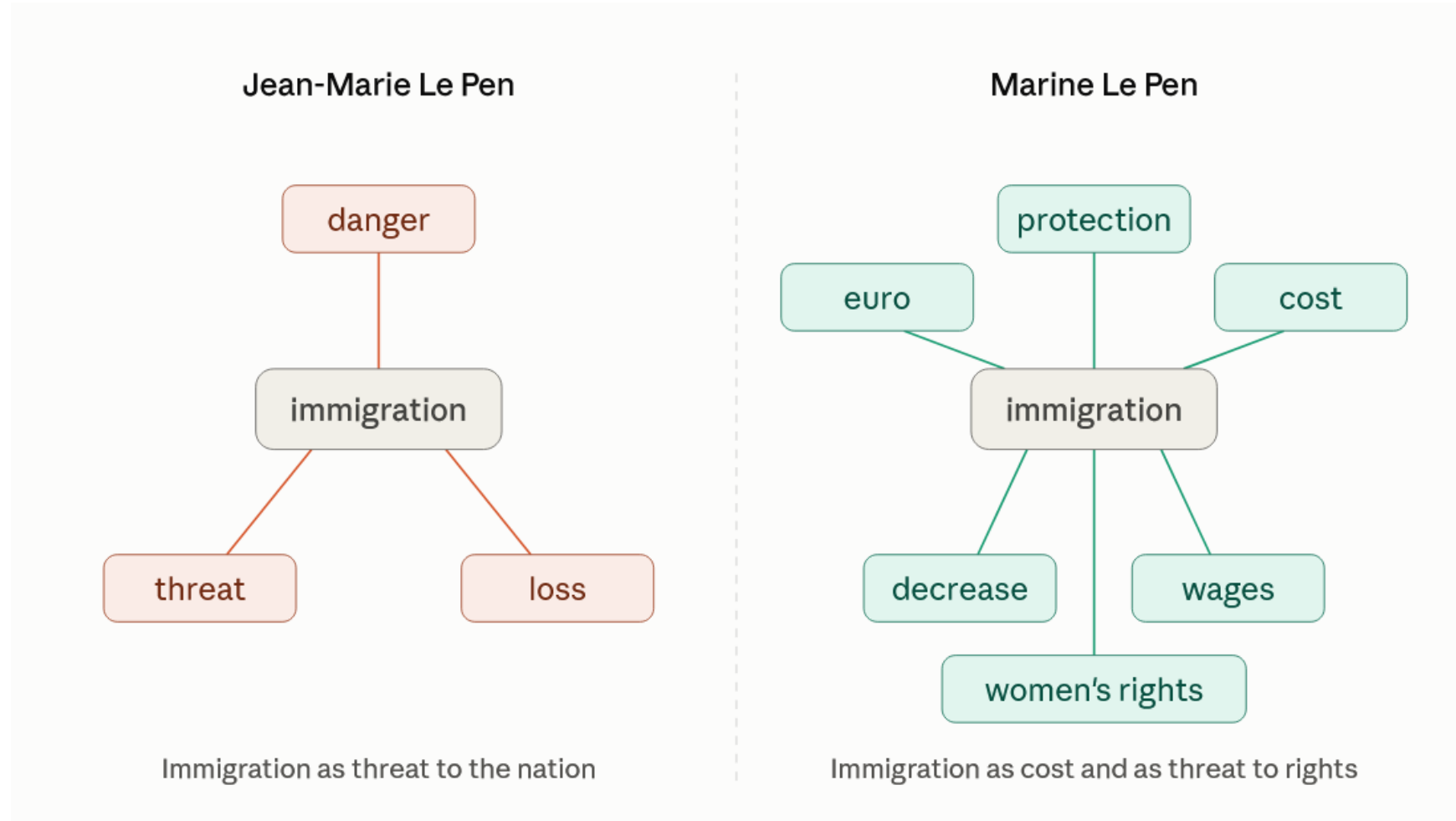
Replaces “Muslim” with “political Islam”

A more respectable radical-right emerges

It does not probe “intent.” It examines discursive links and meanings produced by them

- Discourse analysis does not ask: did Marine Le Pen and her team deliberately manufacture specific discourse?
- The method looks **inside the text** – to map the link between words, symbols, histories, implicit references, which produce meanings

For example*: the words they find associated with 'immigration.' The old discourse and the new discourse



* AI generated mapping

Strengths/weaknesses of discourse analysis:

□ Strengths

- **Analyzes how language constructs political reality:** Goes beyond what is said to examine how things become thinkable or “**common sense**”
- **Traces ideological patterns:** Identifies how dominant discourses normalize power and frame debates
 - e.g., using terms like “the people,” rather than “white Christians”
- **Uncovers messages and assumptions in speech, sounds, and visuals**

□ □ Weaknesses

- **Can overlook overall context and political/social structures:** Focus on language could underplay economic, social, or institutional structures shaping politics
- **Over-supply of online materials today:** online text is easily available, it is easier to do discourse analysis now than other types of interpretive research, at the expense of all those other arenas where politics happen (i.e. politics aren't only online)

In Conclusion: Today we looked at

- Clifford Geertz (1973) on a **wink versus a blink**; the importance of meaning
- Dvora Yanow (2009) : on how political science research also has research methods focusing on meaning – interpretive methods, **like archaeologists of the present**.
- Interpretive methods are **often qualitative – but not necessarily** - and vice versa. The example of Mudde and Kaltwasser (2017) on populism. **Qualitative but not interpretive**.
- We looked at three interpretive methods studying radical-right populism:
 - Geva's (2020) **interviews** – showing gendered understanding of MLP as a populist figure (maternity, virility)
 - Geva's (2020) **participant observation** – showing fixation on MLP's body, also expression of populist feelings of connectivity to MLP as a leader
 - Alduy and Wahnich's **discourse analysis** (2015) – on normalization of the populist radical right through a subtl shift in language

For each interpretive method; we also look at **strengths and weaknesses** of these approaches